

was as if they had accomplished this incredible dream. That's when I realised that I may have won the bronze, but I wanted the kind of happiness that the Belgian team had. A part of us probably felt satisfied with what we had accomplished. But when I saw the final, I saw just how the Belgian players were hugging each other. They had worked so hard for so many years. That's when I realised gold is something else. That's where I want to go. That's where I want the team to go," he says.

It was in chasing this goal that Hardik says he pushed himself too hard. "After the Olympics, I was made vice-captain of the team and I started taking that responsibility in an unhealthy way. I was really being hard on myself. After training sessions, I wouldn't talk to anyone and just go quietly to my room. I was getting really tired of playing hockey at that point. I was always angry with myself, thinking, 'Is this how an Olympic medallist plays?'" he says.

It was around then that Paddy Upton, who had been appointed as a mental conditioning coach with the Indian team, helped him out. "Paddy Upton changed my mindset and taught me that it's okay to make mistakes, even if you are an elite athlete. He gave me the example of Virat Kohli, who was also hard on himself and doing some of the other things I was doing to myself. Paddy told me that my personality is also similar to that of Virat. At that time, I didn't really think much of cricket. It wasn't jealousy, but I always felt they were rewarded for not doing half the work we hockey players did. But I slowly learnt to appreciate what Virat was doing. He is someone who doesn't need appreciation or care what others think. He knows how good he is. I thought, *Baat sahi keh raha hai*. (He's saying the right thing.) I know my capability. I don't need anyone's appreciation. I know I am a game changer. If I can't perform in one match, it's fine. I'll perform in the other match," he says.

If Upton changed his mindset, it was coach Craig Fulton who, Hardik says, changed the way he thought about the game.

"I don't think I changed a lot technically, but tactically I'm a very different player compared to a few years back. I used to have a very one-dimensional, locked game. But coach Fulton opened my style. He got me to start thinking not just about the play I had to make but also about different plans. He's also someone who knows what to say at the right time. At the Paris Olympics, I had two *bakwas* (terrible) matches. I think it was because I was trying too hard. He told me, 'Don't look for the fire. It's already inside you,'" he says.

What followed was the match against Australia, where India picked up its first Olympic win in over 52 years against that formidable opponent. For Hardik, though, that victory wasn't the shock others made it out to be.

"We just knew *ki Australia ko thokna hai* (we had to smash Australia). We had played a series against them and lost every one of five games. And at the end of the tour, we had a team meeting and the coach asked if we thought we could beat Australia. And everyone said yes! Even after that 5-0 defeat, everyone believed in this Indian team," he says.

Unsatisfied with bronze

But while India would go on to win its second consecutive Olympic bronze, Hardik says that familiar feeling of dissatisfaction still lingered.

"It's strange because I had a much better tournament in Paris than in Tokyo, but I actually felt worse at the end of it. In 2021, I knew Belgium were better than us. But this time I knew we were at the same level, if not better, than everyone. We were going toe to toe with Germany. We knew that if we went for a shootout, we could have won — and our record with the Netherlands wasn't bad," he says.

Once again, though, he's found ways to live with the result.

"We lost in the semis in both the Olympics that we have played. Very often I'll think how I came really close on both occasions to making it to the Olympic final and maybe even winning, but wasn't able to make it

count. But then I also think there is a reason. Germany lost to us in 2021 and then they won the World Cup the next year and got silver in the next Olympics. So maybe something like that might happen to us," he says.

For now, Hardik has memorialised the incompleteness of his twin Olympic experience with a tattoo on his arm. Around his bicep are the four Olympic rings, with the topmost ones only partially inked.

"The Olympics are unfinished for me. I am thankful for whatever we achieved, but at the same time there's something left to be achieved. It's only when I win that Olympic gold that I'll fill that gap," he says.

There's a long way to go before the Los Angeles Games in 2028. There are the Asian Games and the World Championships next year. There's also the 2025-26 Pro League, which started strongly but hasn't gone the way India would have hoped, with multiple defeats in Europe over the past few weeks.

While recent results haven't been encouraging, Hardik speaks of seeing them in perspective.

"I think one of the challenges of the Pro League is figuring out which combination is best for the Indian team. It's different between us and teams in Europe simply because of the nature of our squads. In India, the squad usually starts out with 33 people. That means eventually you have to give chances to all of them. In Europe, the squads are usually smaller. A lot of the reason for that is simply that we are a much bigger country," he says.

Special team

Bigger doesn't always mean better and, indeed, Hardik says there are often challenges in getting the Indian squad to work as one.

"Indian hockey is an all-India sport. Most of India's wrestlers are from Haryana, most badminton players are from Telangana. Hockey is a game where North, East, West, South, Kerala, Tamil Nadu, North East, UP, Punjab — all produce players. Sometimes it's difficult to get all these players to gel together. Some are shy, and others from the